



Twists and turns: India topped the list of dropped catches with 16, followed by Ireland, Sri Lanka, and South Africa with 10 each. **Right:** Strategic match-ups and spin-friendly conditions meant that part-time spinners like Rachin Ravindra were a big hit, making an impact beyond their primary roles. K. R. DEEPAK & PTI

Despite being one of the most attacking teams in the lead-up to the tournament, Australia missed a semifinal berth for the third time in a row since claiming its maiden T20 World Cup crown in 2021. The absence of pace spearheads Pat Cummins and Josh Hazlewood hit the team the hardest, with the newer crop of quicks failing to make incisions in key contests and exposing the dire lack of depth in the country's pace stocks.

In their defeats to Zimbabwe and Sri Lanka, the Aussies could claim just four wickets across both games. **The spectacular collective failure of Australia's pantheon of hard-hitting all-rounders — Cameron Green, Glenn Maxwell and Marcus Stoinis — was decisive in the team's group-stage exit.**

Sri Lanka missed a golden opportunity to capitalise on home comforts and the tailwind provided by a clinical victory against the Aussies in the group stage.



Ironically, the co-host was beaten at its own game as it capitulated in spin-friendly conditions, with heavy defeats against England and New Zealand spelling doom for its Super Eights campaign.

The troika of Will Jacks, Adil Rashid and Liam Dawson spun Sri Lanka out for 95 in Kandy, while Rachin Ravindra, Mitchell Santner and Glenn Phillips restricted it to 107 in Colombo. Sri Lankan batters ended their campaign with the worst average (24.26) and run rate (6.69) against spin in the middle overs among Full Member participants in the tournament.

The oft-quoted 'catches win matches' phrase would have rung loudly in England skipper Harry Brook's ears after he dropped a dolly at mid-on to give Sanju Samson a lifeline on 15. Samson went on to plunder 89 in a semifinal that India eventually won by just seven runs. But Brook wouldn't be the only one rueing a missed opportunity. Despite the overall level of fitness and athleticism in the game being higher than ever, this T20 World Cup witnessed the most dropped catches in a single edition of the tournament.

As many as 126 opportunities were missed, with champion India's 16 dropped catches leading the list of ignominy, followed by Ireland, Sri Lanka and South Africa (10 each).